

Understanding Food Insecurity in the United States

Patterns Across States, Key Risk Factors, and Consequences for Public Health

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Sources: USDA ERS, CDC BRFSS, ACS, Feeding America (2023)

US Population Snapshot 2023

How Many People Struggle With Food Insecurity in America?

Americans Facing Food Insecurity

48.4M

≈ 1 in 7 Americans

Food-Insecure Children

13.3M

Children under 18

Food-Insecure Older Adults

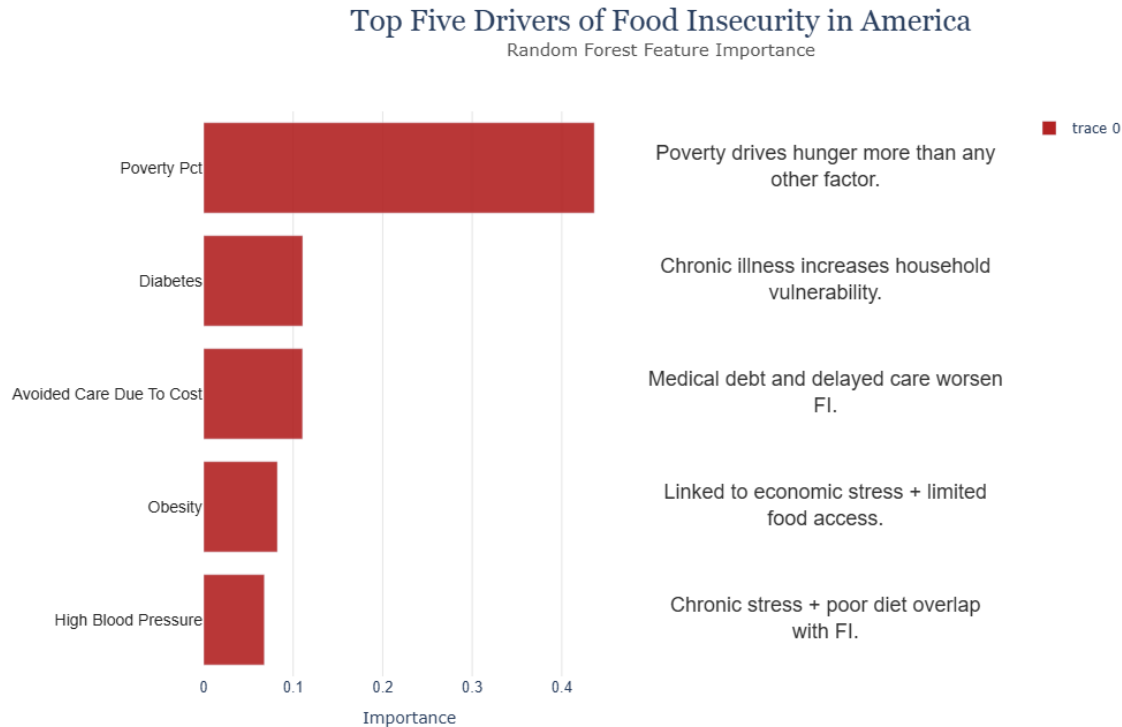
7.1M

Ages 60+

Source: USDA Economic Research Service (2023) — Food Security Report.

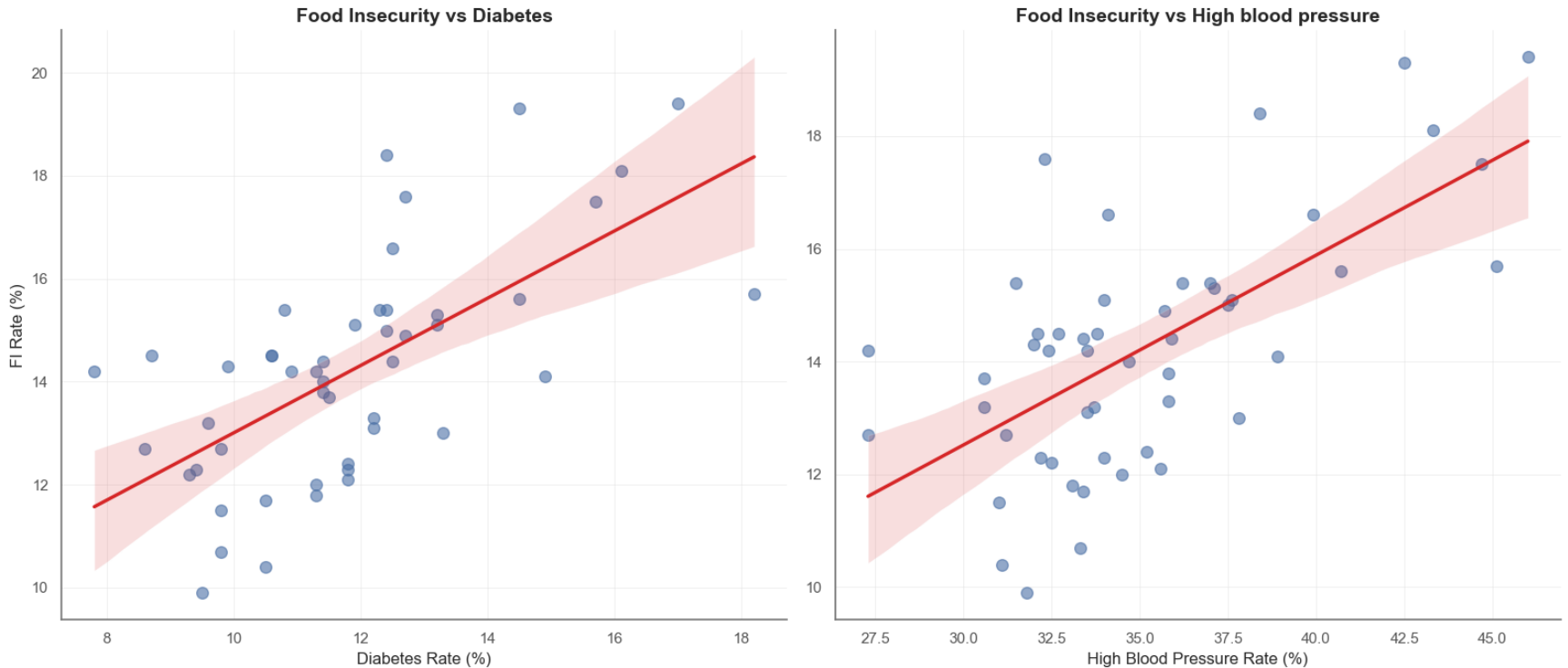
Food insecurity does not hit all groups equally. Nationally, around **48 million people** face uncertainty about their next meal. The burden is highest among **children** and **older adults**, groups that are especially vulnerable to long-term developmental and health impacts.

Drivers of Food Insecurity



When we examine the drivers side by side, we see a consistent pattern: states with higher **poverty**, **income inequality**, and **housing cost burden** show significantly higher food insecurity. Healthcare access is also a critical factor — particularly the share of people who avoid care due to cost. These indicators reinforce that food insecurity is not only about food availability, but about affordability and economic stability

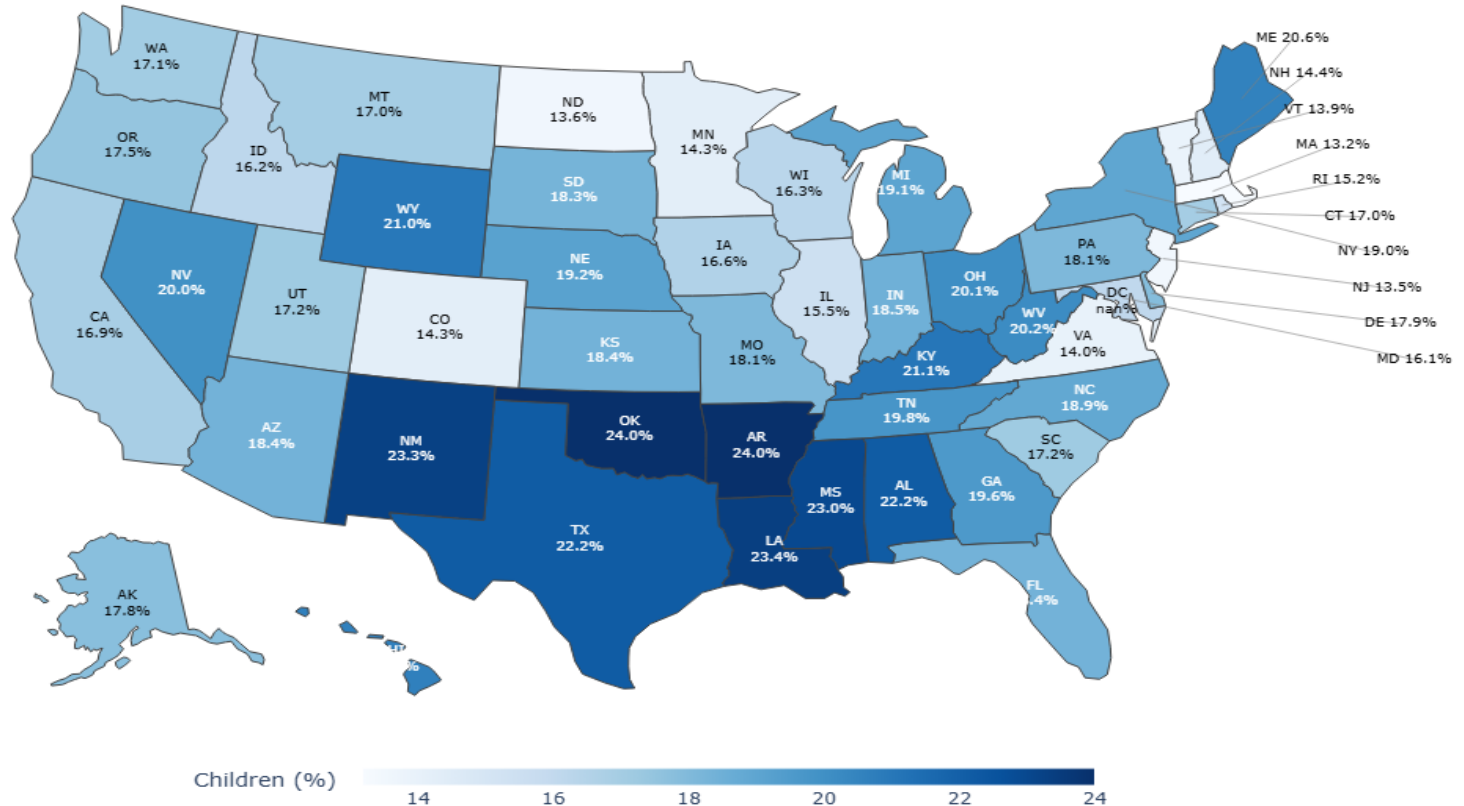
Food Insecurity & Health Risks



This charts highlights the correlation between food insecurity and chronic diseases. The relationship is strongest with **diabetes** and **high blood pressure**. These conditions are closely linked to diet quality, healthcare access, and economic stress. The higher the food insecurity rate in a state, the higher the prevalence of these chronic health challenges tends to be.

Child Food Insecurity

Food Insecurity Among Children (2023)
Northeast labels aligned in a vertical column with leader lines



For children, food insecurity is especially damaging. This map shows where children face the greatest barriers to nutrition. The geographic patterns are clear: the problem concentrates in parts of the South and Southwest, but also appears in pockets of Appalachia and the Northeast. These elevated rates among children create long-term risk for lower academic achievement, health complications, and lower lifetime earnings.

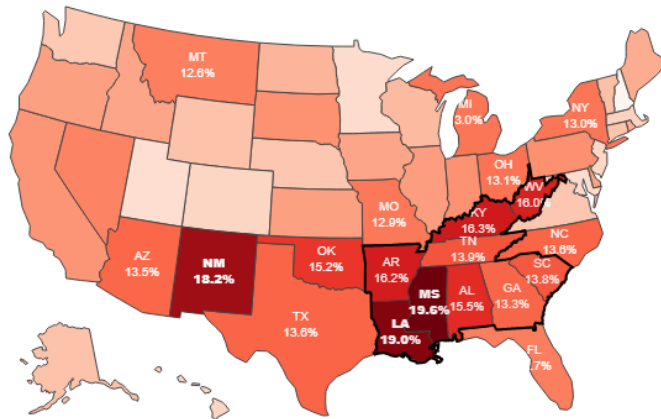
Poverty & FI Maps

Source: USDA ERS; Feeding America; ACS 2023

Poverty & Food Insecurity Across the United States (2023)

Labels shown only for the 20 hardest-hit states

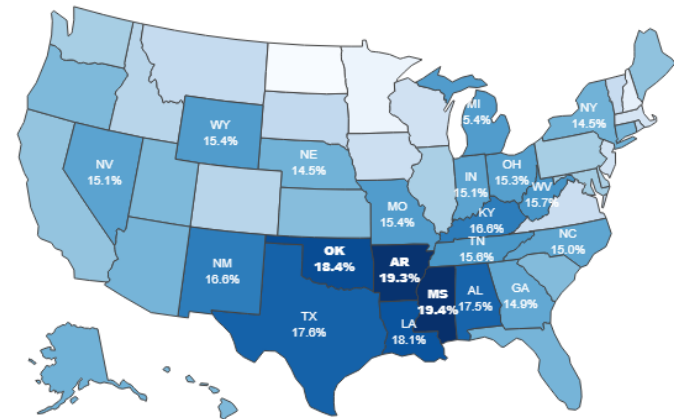
Top 20 States by Poverty Rate (2023)



Deep South 'Poverty Belt' highlighted
Persistent structural poverty + weak safety nets



Top 20 States by Food Insecurity Rate (2023)



When we compare poverty rates and food insecurity side by side, the overlap is striking. States with high poverty — like Mississippi, Louisiana, Arkansas, and New Mexico — also experience the highest food insecurity. However, the differences matter too: some states show higher food insecurity than poverty would predict, which indicates additional factors like housing costs, transportation, and access to food retailers play important roles

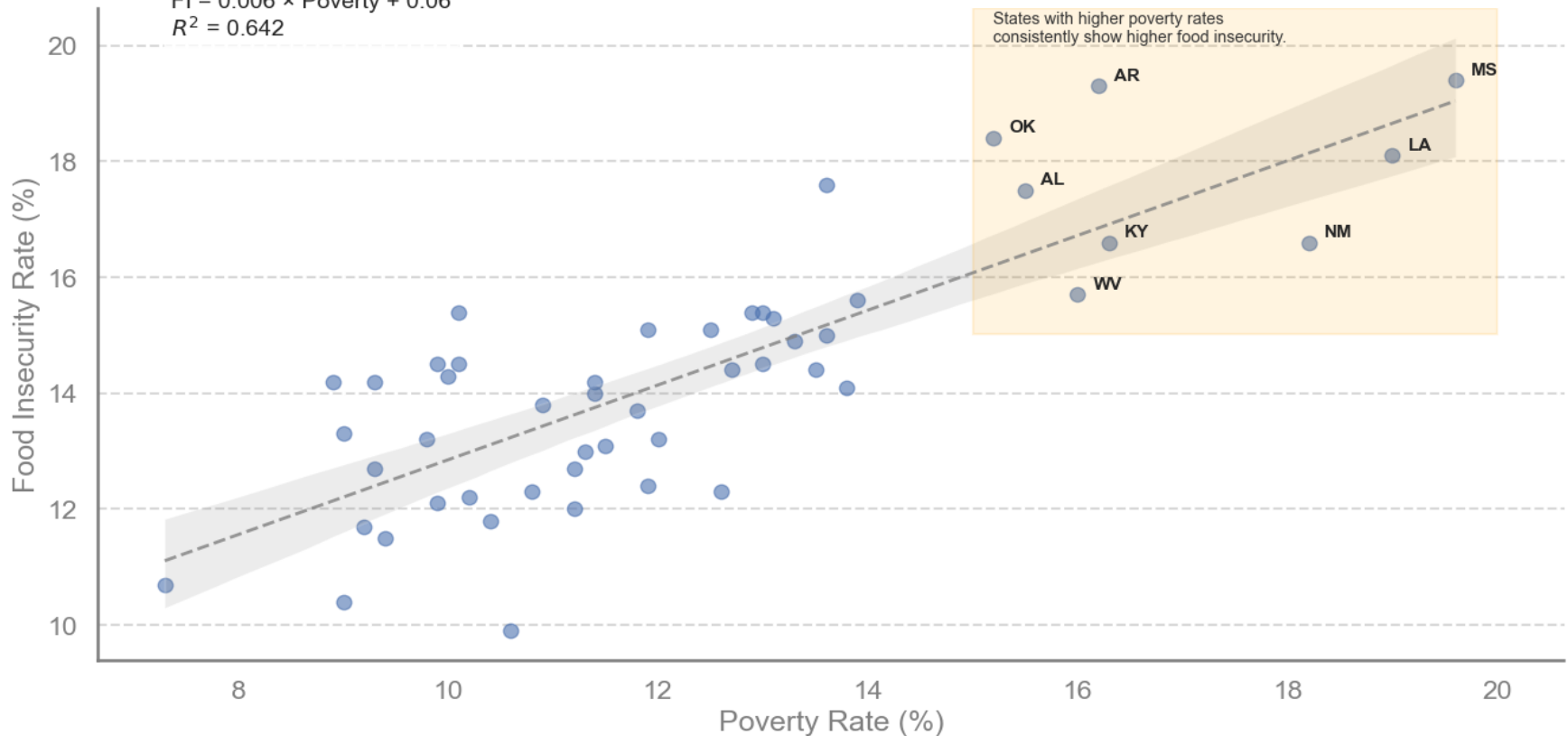
Poverty vs FI Relationship

Poverty is the Primary Driver of Food Insecurity

Reducing poverty is the most direct way to reduce hunger in America.

$$FI = 0.006 \times \text{Poverty} + 0.06$$

$$R^2 = 0.642$$

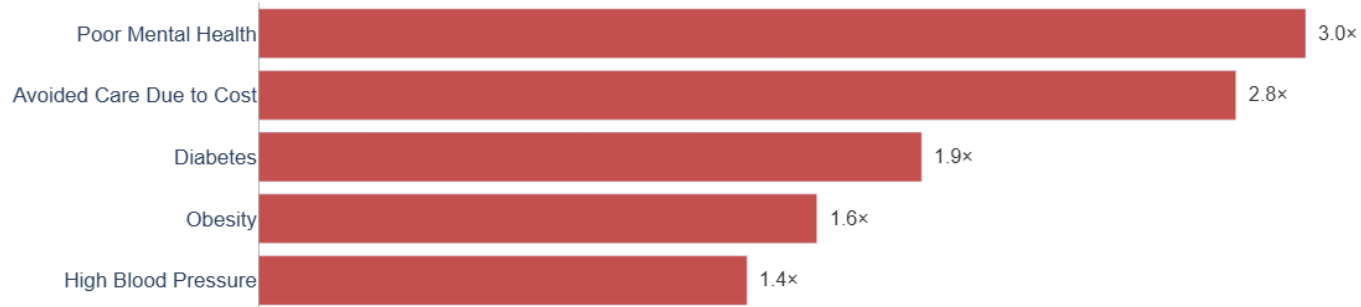


Source: USDA Economic Research Service, 2023

A quantitative look confirms the strong linear relationship. Food insecurity rises by approximately **1.2 percentage points** for every **1 point increase in poverty rate**. This makes poverty the single most influential predictor in our model. From a policy standpoint, this highlights why anti-poverty interventions are also food security interventions

Health Risk Multipliers

How Food Insecurity Raises the Risk of Major Health Problems



Source: USDA ERS & CDC BRFSS (2023)

Food insecurity amplifies health risks across multiple categories.

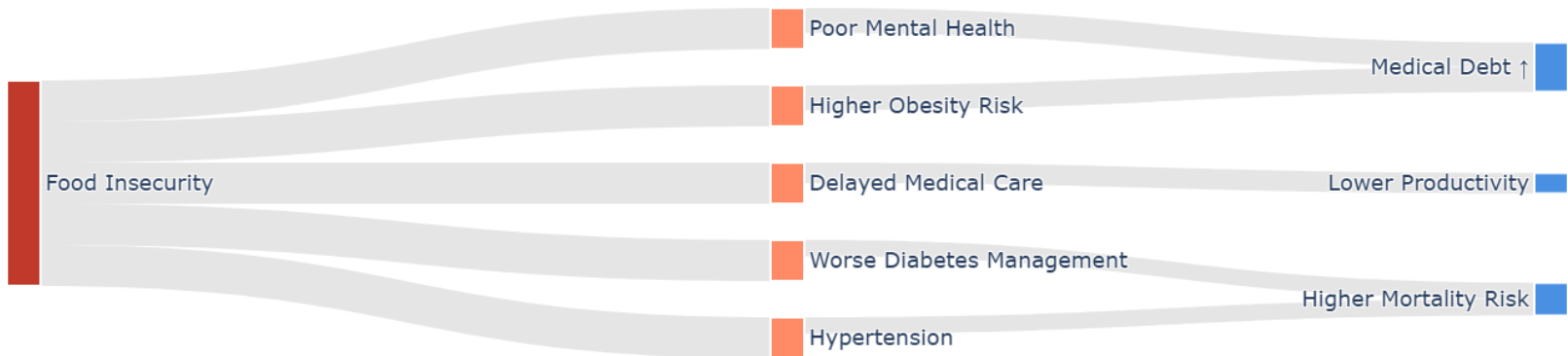
Individuals facing food insecurity have:

- A **2× higher risk of diabetes complications**
- A **1.7× higher risk of hypertension instability**
- A **1.8× higher risk of frequent mental distress**
- A **2–3× higher likelihood of delaying medical care**

These multipliers underline that food insecurity has cascading impacts on both physical and mental health.

Consequences of Food Insecurity

Consequences of Food Insecurity in America



We can think of food insecurity as the starting point of a broader chain reaction. Economic stress leads to poorer diet quality, which elevates chronic health risks, which then increases out-of-pocket healthcare costs. These health-related financial burdens feed back into the household budget, making food insecurity worse. It's a self-reinforcing cycle that requires policy intervention to break.